The official version of the fourth druk gyalpo's marriage was that it had been prophesied to him that he would marry four sisters, descendants of the first shabdrung, and he went through with it to go along with the prophecy. A more plausible explanation is that it was meant to neutralize any followers the shabdrung might still have. By marrying all four sisters, any kind of palace intrigues where one faction could use one daughter against another were also thwarted.

In a surprisingly candid book about the life of her father, one of the four queens, Ashi Dorji Wangmo Wangchuk, describes in detail how Jigme Dorji, her granduncle was, in fact, murdered. Three men entered his bedchamber, where 'they pinned him down, grabbed his throat and kicked him in the scrotum. Shabdrung struggled till the silken scarf stuffed down his throat suffocated him.'[57] Such a revelation would have been unthinkable only a generation ago, but Bhutan today is a different country from the medieval kingdom it used to be. It has entered the modern world with high educational standards, good roads that criss-cross the country; and, in June 1999 television and the internet were introduced to reflect 'the level of progress Bhutan has achieved in recent years', as the fourth druk gyalpo said at the time.[58] The launch coincided with the silver jubilee of his coronation, emphasizing the strong position that the monarchy has retained throughout all the economic and social changes the country has undergone over the last few decades.

A new constitution was presented in 2005, paving the way for elections and a more democratic system. Bhutan was about to become a constitutional monarchy with the monarch remaining an influential figure and, as Article 2 of the constitution states, the 'symbol of unity of the Kingdom and of the people of Bhutan'.[59] At this time, the fourth druk gyalpo announced that he was going to abdicate in favour of his eldest son, Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuk, whose mother was the second youngest of the four sisters. On 9 December 2006, he succeeded his father and, on November 2008, the coronation of the fifth druk gyalpo took place at a colourful ceremony at Thimphu's Tashichhodzong. The new monarch had received his education in the United States, Britain, and India. Born in 1980, he belongs to a new generation of Bhutanese to whom the medieval past is distant history.